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Fred Wesley

Fred Wesley has enjoyed a creative life as a trombonist, composer, arranger, and band leader. His contributions to the sound of James Brown band and Parliament-Funkadellic is unmistakable and integral to their success.

Fred was interviewed via Zoom on November 21, 2024 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: I have to do. There we go, right?

FW: Right.

MR: Okay. All right. So I prepared some — My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive and I'm very pleased to have Mr. Fred Wesley with me today, a trombonist, arranger, composer, band leader, and as a high school student skipped his father's social studies class to hang out in the band room.

FW: I couldn't leave. I tried to make my father's social studies class. I couldn't leave. I was in the middle of blues changes and I just couldn't leave, I couldn't leave for nothing.

MR: One of my favorite subjects — was there a point where you were learning not only the trombone and the baritone, but you started to get this thing like okay there's this blues form, what is this. Did someone show you or did it sort of just enter your consciousness because of the playing?

FW: You know I learned how to improvise blues before I learned how to play the trombone you know. I was just playing stuff that was in my head you know. And then I found out when I got in my father's band I had to read music and I had to learn how to play the trombone you know. So I learned what I had to learn after I learned how to improvise.

MR: Did spending time at the piano help with the improvising? Because I know, I read in your book that you had the typical sort of classical lessons, but, I actually have a quote here. You wrote: " I just didn't want to be this Glen Howard guy who played the hell out of Rachmaninoff. I wanted to play the shit out of the trombone solo in "Things Ain't What They Used to Be."

FW: Yeah, yeah. Well you know Gwen Howard was a girl. And I didn't want to play that nice little dainty music like girls played you know. I wanted to play like "Things Ain't What It Used to Be." So that was in my head you know. I can play the boogie woogie on the piano with my left hand and in my right hand I played the chord. I didn't know what I was doing but I was hearing it in my head you know. So that's what I learned before I learned music. You know? I knew how to play, how to improvise and how to make up music before I knew how to write it down and what it was about to write it down. You know. In fact I didn't learn that stuff until I got with James Brown, you know?

MR: Well you set up one of my questions that I've really been curious about so we can jump there. I used to be — I've been in a lot of bands and as a horn player for some reason I got the job of writing out the horn parts that we were hearing on records. And it was a laborious process, especially with those funk rhythms and all the sixteenth rests. When you talked about not doing that until you were with James Brown, was it tedious for you to write those parts out or didn't you even write them out?

FW: It was very tedious. And I did write some of them out. Some of them I just gave to the guys you know, for them to play. What instrument do you play?

MR: Saxophone.

FW: Saxophone. Well I gave a saxophone player this part, trombone, the trumpet player their part. But I had to write out the music when I had to use the New York studio musicians on the session. And I really didn't know how to do it and I had to write them out as we rode on the bus. So I didn't have a piano, I didn't have a trombone, I couldn't play the trombone, I had to — it was a tedious, tedious process you know. And like you said, a tedious process that I had to do and I had to find out what note was — find one note and then find another note from that one note that I knew you know. And it was a very tedious process. But it worked out real good for me because now I knew how to do that kind of automatically you know, without knowing what I'm doing. You know?

MR: There is something about that statement it's just so wonderful. Like you know what you're doing but you don't know what you're doing.

FW: Yeah.

MR: I guess you mean that from a theoretical standpoint, that students learn now in jazz school and so forth. But is it harder to write for two horns or five?

FW: Well definitely it's harder to write for five horns, you know, because you have to hear all the notes in the chords and the movements of the different instruments you know. And you have to — like alto — I've never learned how to write for alto really good you know, because it was in between and the B flat horns and the C horns. You know? And you have to hear that kind of stuff and write it down. It was very tedious you know. But I didn't mind doing it, if it took me all night and all day sometimes so that I'd just sleep for days you know. But I learned by doing you know.

MR: Did you have a score pad on the bus?

FW: Sometimes. Sometimes I did. I eventually got a score pad. But usually I would just write it out. You'd be surprised what I used to write on. Sometimes I'd draw a staff and write on the staff you know. But yeah, I finally got that score pad, when I found out what a score pad was. And I said, oh you can do it? It's already written out? You know, so that was a shortcut for me, when I found out what a score pad was. You know David Matthews and Emile Charlap, they helped me a lot. In fact they kind of taught me how to

write, things that I didn't know how to write. And all that stuff, I said well how do you write for French horns, or how do you write for strings, the violin. And they would tell me, and I've got a whole year of education by just asking the question you know?

MR: These were guys in the band?

FW: No, they was New York — Emile Charlap was a New York contractor. He used to copy all my music for me, and he would show me what I did wrong and what I did right. You know I used to write all the parts out and I saw Dave Matthews, he was a fine arranger you know. And I would write things over and over again and he would draw lines, you know, from one part to another. You know and I said, "Can you do that?" And he said, "Yeah, you can do that." And Emile would write it, he would transpose it for them you know, and when I learned that, that shortened my awake time you know. But that's how I learned, by doing. I learned by doing.

MR: I can picture that because I was listening to "Pass the Peas" you know, and you've got that line [scats]. You could just write it once and put 8 times.

FW: Right. I didn't know how to do that, you know. But now "Pass the Peas" was a James Brown composition. I didn't have anything to do with it except playing a solo on it. Because now James Brown — he would totally tell the band what to play, you know, and anything they didn't understand I would translate it to them from James Brown you know. But James Brown said, "Have the trumpets play this" and "have the saxophones play this" and that you know. And so we learned James Brown's music with the James Brown band by doing too. You know we'd say play this — and they finally understood what I was talking about and I understood what they were talking about and so that's how we were successful with "Give Me Some Mo'", "Pass the Peas" and even "Gonna Have a Funky Good time." That was just talking, talking, talking it up and Jabo would play a shuffle. They'd say, "Jabo play a shuffle." He would play a shuffle and the bass player would play [scats] and I had to figure out what [scats] what that was you know. And then I would translate it to the bass player. "Play this." You know? And Fred Thomas would play [scats] and you put it all together and it would become a song you know. The guitar player would play, I didn't know what the rhythm was — I still haven't ever written [scats] I haven't written that out, but if you just tell the guitar to play [scats] — do because we call those head arrangements. And so those head arrangements became big hits you know.

MR: Yes.

FW: But then a tune like "Down and Out in New York City" those had to be written out by me from what James Brown told me. James Brown would say, "Have the horns do this, he wants the flutes to do this, you know, ridiculous things you know. But I would make it work you know. And the musicians in the studio would make it work too. They would

have the music written out. I remember Steve Gadd would play stuff that if you never thought to write, but he would just play things you know with the bass player. What was his name? I can't think of his name right now. But he'd ask me, say, "Well where are the changes?" I'd say, "There are no changes here."

MR: There's one.

FW: [Scats]. And he refused to do that. But when I finally broke him down to where he would do it, he did the hell out of it. So some things happened automatically, some things happened just because they were written down and they played it exactly like it was written you know.

MR: I was thinking, while you were just saying that, I thought of Pharoah Sanders because a lot of his music stayed on one chord for a long time. And I don't have a question here except that it seems like you have to have a long attention span and just get into that rhythm so much that it doesn't become boring. Because if it becomes boring it's not going to work.

FW: Right. Well I can't think of this bass player's name.

MR: Anton Figg perhaps?

FW: No. Anyway you are exactly right, if it becomes boring to them then it's not happening you know. But if it fits with the other music and the other musicians, and they lock it in together and it becomes good to you, you know, what you play becomes really good to your soul you know, you love to do it. And when you do it, you do it automatically, without even thinking about it, and the same notes or the same chords become wonderful chords to you and you don't get bored.

MR: Were the musicians that were on the road in the working band, were they somewhat aggravated by not playing on the records?

FW: Well some — you know they knew that certain tunes they wouldn't be able to play. You know, like "Down and Out in New York City" I used that as an example because there was a lot of notes in there that they couldn't reach, and a lot of rhythms that they couldn't do. You know you had to have some skill to do what — some things I had to write out and they could look at it and then see it. But they understood that it was stuff they couldn't do and I would have to get the real musicians to do it too. I say "real musicians" I mean the studious kind of learned musicians, to do it.

MR: Yeah. And they could do it, probably the second time around if the parts had been prepared correctly.

FW: Maybe the third time around. You know? Yeah. Things would happen like that you know. I'm sorry, I can't remember this bass player's name because we had so much — well we started out aggravated with each other you know, but we ended up being good friends.

MR: We'll think of it later, you know, after we sign off we'll probably both think of it.

FW: Yeah.

MR: Well you were enamored early on with bebop.

FW: Yeah.

MR: Is there a difference and a challenge either way about improvising on a bebop tune with multiple chord changes and often times at a fast tempo rather than improvising on one chord. What's the difference that's going on in your head between those two?

FW: Well on one chord you have to vary what you play, you have to make it sound like it's a lot of chords you know. I guess you would play different things the same way you know. I can't explain it exactly but with one chord you would do, you could up and down, the music goes up and down rather than sideways. You know? But for bebop you've got total freedom to follow the changes, right? But when you only have one change then you have to play it up and down. Do you understand? Up and down is better than sideways. It's a different approach to the way you do it. You know?

MR: I remember referring to — reading about Coleman Hawkins that way, that they were talking about he played vertical instead of horizontal.

FW: Right. Vertical, horizontal.

MR: Something like that. And certainly you've got a rhythmic aspect when you're playing on one chord that you really need to personify and stress to make it interesting.

FW: Well the same with changes, you had to be rhythmical with that too. You have to understand that vertical and horizontal is only as good as the rhythm that you make it be. You know?

MR: You know some things I believe don't need to be explained.

FW: Yeah, yeah. Buster Williams Junior.

MR: Buster Williams Junior?

FW: Yes. He was the bass player that gave me big trouble in the beginning.

MR: Is he the son of Buster Williams?

FW: No. I mean this is the real Buster Williams.

MR: Oh this is Buster Williams. Wow.

FW: Yeah. Yeah.

MR: Oh. He's one of my favorites and so he must have been playing, you know like Fender bass instead of —

FW: No, it was an upright bass.

MR: Oh my goodness, wow.

FW: Yeah. Oh I had Ron Carter doing funky lines you know? You look at "Transmogrification" a tune on one of JB's albums, one of the first albums. And Ron

Carter played the same thing but he played it with so much soul and so much feeling that you thought he was playing "So What." You know? Yeah.

MR: Was there a point during college or after that you had to make a decision about, financially, what kind of music should I be playing? Should I pursue being in the jazz world or did things just happen to you to steer you in another direction?

FW: Things just happened to me to steer me in another direction. I took the job with James Brown with the intent of getting to a large city — I come from a small town in Alabama — Mobile, Alabama — and you know it's not much chance of being heard and being known as a jazz musician in Mobile, Alabama. You know? So I wanted to get to New York and I wanted to get to L.A. or Chicago, somewhere where I could be heard — to play the jazz that I knew I could play you know. But so I took the job with James Brown but I had no intention of staying with him but for the seven years that I did stay with him you know, because I only wanted to get in New York City, go to the jam sessions, and that would be it you know. I'll be the next great jazz trombone player you know. But it didn't happen like that. Because when I got in the James Brown band I found out that I liked it. You know? And it was fun and it was good — good for my body and good for my soul too. Because he was doing some interesting things, you know James Brown had a tight show. And that show was above what the music would dictate. You know he was doing "Cold Sweat." "Cold Sweat" when I first heard "Cold Sweat" I didn't like it at all because it was wrong, it was wrong musically, but Pee Wee Ellis had made it so that it would be an interesting song you know. And so I liked it, even though — with one change, or a few changes you know. But so but that's why I stayed with James Brown. But then when I got to be the band leader I was really going to take over you know. But as you know James Brown did not like it when people tried to take over his band so he fired me you know. And I had to go to California. I said, "Oh good, this will be my chance." I went to California, moved my family to California to pursue my jazz playing on the West Coast. But I found out they had people like George Bohanan and Frank Fontana and — already out there. Garnett Brown was already out there you know. So there wasn't much call for another jazz trombone player, even though I was considerably better than they are but from what I thought you know. So I played with another funk band. And we didn't do real good, we kind of starved to death. But I got my job back with James Brown and that's when I decided to make the most out of that job. And so that's why I became "Fred Wesley and the J.B.'s" and that's why we have those hits with "Pass the Peas" and "Doing it to Death" and all that stuff you know.

MR: And you're still touring? Good for you, man. I think it keeps you young I believe.

FW: Well mentally yeah, but your body just gets to be old, you know, before you know it. I feel old today you know because I've got a cough. And I'm 81 now you know so things

go wrong you know but it's still a good feeling when you get out there and play your horn, you know, you feel it. But the traveling part gets to be a very difficult job you know, so I'm having to slow down but I still love the music, still love to play.

MR: I was thinking about that, if you did the math about how many hours you spend getting to a gig, getting home from a gig, getting from one to another, and then you balance it with what — the time you're actually on stage having a great time.

FW: Yeah. We often talk about that, all the time, you know say the real job, what we really get paid for is the travel. But it's what you do for free is the gig. But you know that's always fun. When it's over with, back to the traveling. You've got to go back to the hotel and pack your stuff and get ready to go. And that's the job again. So it's two aspects of it, and one aspect is harder than the other, but you love the other so much that you'd do it for free, you know.

MR: When you were writing the horn parts for the groups that you were in, did you keep in mind who the players were?

FW: Oh yeah.

MR: Yeah. I remember thinking about like Ellington used to write not for a tenor sax, he'd write for Ben Webster.

FW: Yeah, yeah. Like I had to write something for the horns, I knew what Maceo could do. I knew what Russell Crimes could do and I knew what Ike Oakley could do. I knew what each player could do. So I wouldn't write over their heads, I wouldn't write under their heads either. I'd let Maceo take the lead on some things, you know, over the trumpets you know. Because he was a far better musician than Russell Crimes. See he was a good musician but he couldn't play certain notes you know. So yeah I did. I did write for the musicians. You know? Yeah.

MR: In any of the videos I've seen of James Brown and your group, in fact one I just looked at from 2023 I rarely see a music stand on stage, which means people are memorizing their music. Is that correct?

FW: That is correct, yeah. I just had to fire a saxophone player because he couldn't memorize the music and he couldn't fit in with what the band did you know. I mean he's a beautiful guy you know but he just couldn't get it. So I had to fire him. But the trumpet player and the other saxophone player that I hired they seem to get it automatically because they can memorize real good and they can fit in real good with the other horn players in the section. You know? But that is true, we don't use music stands and — you have to feel what we do. You know?

MR: I'm curious if the difference between those horn players and their memorizing, if you think it had anything to do with their music education? And the reason I ask is over the

years the bands I've played in the musicians who did not go to music school and were self taught were much better at memorizing things.

FW: Yeah.

MR: Because their ears had been developed to that point.

FW: You could really tell by my playing. You know? I can memorize stuff better than I can read music you know? I did jobs where I would have to read music. In fact I don't take jobs where I have to read music now because I don't read that well. I never read that well you know. I used to play, we'd play American Idol and with Count Basie, and you know you had to read music to do that, but you had to feel what the band was doing. You would have to feel that music rather than read it all the time. Sometimes you had to feel it and read it, like Count Basie's band. You have to feel it. And I play with a lot of big bands like that, and I could keep the job because I could feel it better than I could read it. You know what I mean? The cats would help you. When I was with Basie's band the band, the trombone players, they saw that I could feel the music and they knew that I couldn't read the music that well but they tolerated me. [to phone — call me back] they tolerated me because I felt the music so good. And that's a lot of things — I'd get a lot of gigs like that where I'm tolerated because I can feel the music and I remember the music even if I can't read it right off. You know?

MR: Yeah. I remember looking at your sort of chronology and thinking after all those years of playing in funk bands did you have to sort of re-set when you got with Basie and like remember how to swing?

FW: Oh no. I didn't have to remember nothing.

MR: That was still inside you, right?

FW: Oh that music that locks into your body and you just hope the notes are right you know, because the Basie groove is a one time thing. It's the best groove in the world I think.

MR: I totally agree. There's something about that rhythm section that just seemed like it was one instrument. They self-balanced themselves, they didn't depend on a sound man to do that, it's just like a phenomenon.

FW: In fact Basie used to tell sound men, "Set it and forget it, go sit down somewhere, we will adjust among ourselves." You know. In fact the whole band adjusted among themselves. They would play soft and they would play loud, and when they would play among themselves they would adjust the way it should be played you know. And somehow they all knew what to do or when to do it. You know?

MR: As the new guy in the band you must have done a lot of observing to figure out how they were doing that?

FW: Well the Count Basie band I kind of knew. I kind of knew what they were doing and how they were doing it. In fact the way I got to keep the Basie gig is because I listened to Bill

Hughes, the bass trombone player. And he would kind of lead the band from the bottom. And Mel Wanzo wasn't the best trombone player in the world but he could play that music the way it was supposed to be played. You know? And so I was listening to the two of them and the other two trombone players and we kind of locked together. You know Dennis Wilson, he was a perfectly well trained musician. He wrote arrangements with a ball point pen. Full band arrangements and he never made a mistake. And I just admired that so much you know. And I learned so much from them. And fell into that groove automatically without anybody telling me what to do you know.

MR: In the arranging you've done, if you think back on it, I'm wondering if something, an artist or a situation comes to your mind that was really challenging and that stretched what you had been doing previously, if it's writing for strings or something like that.

FW: Well the James Brown job was most challenging too because he would — James Brown would just sing stuff off the top of his head but you had to do it. He would say, "Okay use a harp right here." A harp? What did James Brown want with a harp in his band you know? But he had to have this harp, and he'd say, "Okay we want a cello solo in this part." A cello solo? Why? I cannot do this. You know? But you'd have to make it work. Had to make it work. And he would say, ah, you see, you didn't think it would work did you. And he would laugh because he had known, he knew he had challenged me. You know? And he would say, he would tell me to do tunes like "Don't Fence Me In." I'd say now why does James Brown want to do a tune like "Don't Fence Me In"? You know. But the challenge, I came up to the challenge. I wrote an arrangement for it and Warren Bernhardt, he played the clavinet part on it, and it was absolutely beautiful you know. And James Brown was the most challenging musician that I ever worked for because he would say things that were totally ridiculous but you had to make it come out right.

MR: Wow. That is a challenge because people who don't know about the limitations of instruments or in scoring and all that stuff, but they get these marvelous ideas in their head. Like George Martin with the Beatles.

FW: Yeah?

MR: He would translate some of those ideas they had and make them reality.

FW: Oh yeah.

MR: So you're the George Martin of the James Brown — or vice versa. He was the Fred Wesley for the Beatles.

FW: Yeah, yeah.

MR: I prepared a little prop here. This is a list, a discography of Fred Wesley.

FW: Oh my goodness.

MR: You see this? From the internet.

FW: Oh my goodness.

MR: Oh yeah.

FW: Good grief.

MR: It's about eight pages.

FW: I'm getting tired just looking at that.

MR: You wonder how you fit it all in.

FW: Send me that.

MR: That's something I'll try to scan it or maybe — you know what I'll do? I'll take a long bus ride and I'll write it out by hand like you used to do. I can just see — you know I've done that kind of thing. I don't know if I've done it on a bus but I can just picture you like writing a rhythm and you hit a bump.

FW: Yup. Imagine me doing it with a ball point pen like Dennis Wilson did. But —

MR: Well tell me about — does any of the studio work, like all these people you played with, I wonder if anything sticks out in your mind? Vanessa Williams, Red Hot Chili Peppers, Randy Brecker.

FW: Yeah. Randy.

MR: It just goes on and on and on.

FW: Randy Brecker sticks out in my mind because you know what he said? And I find it hard to believe but he said that I influenced his playing. I said now how did I influence Randy Brecker? He's one of the top bebop trumpet players in the world you know. And I influenced his playing you know. He told me that he would listen to my stuff and incorporate it into his stuff you know. And that was amazing to me. I didn't realize that I would influence a great musician like Randy Brecker. But other musicians have told me the same thing. Because I don't know what — I didn't know what I was doing but it was sticking with a lot of people. You know? A lot of great musicians.

MR: I'm going to see if I can focus on that statement which you've said a couple of times, in that you didn't know what you were doing. Can you tell me, is it sort of like I'm playing this note and I really like it so I'm going to hang on it, but what I don't know is its relationship to the chord? Can you just talk about that a little bit?

FW: Well you know 80 percent of what I do is from my ear. So 80 percent of what say Sonny Rollins does is from his eyes. He can see things and play — well Pee Wee Ellis. Pee Wee Ellis is a great example. He sees what he can hear. I hear what I can make music from. I could hear things that he can see from looking at it you know. But it was a natural thing with me. But if you write it out, I'm lost. Because I don't know where — I say well let me hear it. And then they play it and I say, "Okay I'm going to do that." You know? And I don't understand chord progressions. I don't understand how you go from one chord to another. I don't understand how that works but I can hear it. And it's a natural thing. I think it's a gift from God that I can hear things like that. You know? And that is the

difference between what I do and what most musicians do. Most musicians can see and hear, but I can only hear. I can only hear what's happening. You know?

MR: Yeah. Especially in this period we're in now where most musicians do the jazz school, jazz education route, that they're taught about all the chord changes and the scales and all that. So yeah.

FW: But I tell students to first, first learn — because I know most people won't have it naturally like I do. I know that. And I don't know why I have it naturally like that, but I tell them learn your scales, learn your chords, and learn your instrument up and down and sideways. Learn all of that and if you can develop your psyche to be a good musician. But if I tell them how I do it, you probably won't ever learn how to do it. I didn't learn how to do it like that. I didn't learn how to do it. I do it because it's a natural thing with me you know. And I don't understand why but I thank God that I have it because that's why I'm the musician that I am you know.

MR: It has served you well for sure. I want to just backtrack a little bit before we go, and I love those images you talked about in your book of the small big band that would set up in your living room and you would be like setting up the chairs and the stands and all that, like you were a roadie first.

FW: Right.

MR: You were a band boy.

FW: Yup, yup, And all those musicians, the ones that are still alive are still my best friends. You know? All of them. All of them. I loved all of them and their children talk about me. Most of them are gone you know but their kids, like for instance Joe Morris's son has a band. He plays the drums. He just hired me to be at his music festival in Pensacola, Florida on December 1. He hired me. And he said that he thanks me and the other musicians that were his father's friends you know, for his ability to play music. But I told him that he is our legacy. He is my legacy. He is the one that will carry on what we have started you know. Because all of them were great friends of mine.

MR: There's a term you used a couple of times, you were talking about the first time you heard J.J. Johnson and then in a live situation with Ed Pratt's band. And you were listening to these players and you said, "I was wrecked." And I was thinking, well some people the reaction they would have had would be to give up. To say no way, no way am I ever going to do that so I'll find something else to do. But you chose not to give up.

FW: And I didn't give up and I haven't given up yet. J.J., I heard J.J. play a tune, one of his tunes, called "Overdrive." I still can't play it. But the way he played it so fluently and so fluidly. He was — the way he approached those changes — I still cannot do it the way he did it. And I have tried, I tried to record that tune and it's not anything the way J.J. does it. You know so, and I can't say if he got it naturally or maybe he learned how to play

like that. You know? But I think he had the natural ability. Because the way J.J. plays the trombone and the way I play the trombone is very similar. Like we don't play with the double tongue, the double tongue, like most trombone players can do, you know, real good. I can't do that either. You know, but he had a fast tongue and a fast single tongue, and a fast slide. You know? I just found out last week that a lot of tunes that — a lot of positions I play in first position they can play in fourth position. And I never thought about that, I said oh yeah, that's cool. But this thing that we learn late in life that you should have learned in the first place you know. Like I say I can play — I could play before I knew what I was doing.

MR: Let me run a couple of names by you and see if you have any thoughts about them. My favorite is Cannonball and Nat Adderley.

FW: Oh. Cannonball, one of my favorites. He's one of my favorites. He's like the one — this guy just started, picked the horn up and just blew. And Cannonball kind of overshadowed Nat a little bit, but Nat could play too you know. They were both great musicians. Yeah.

MR: Yeah. You could almost tell what kind of person Cannonball was from the way he played.

FW: Yeah. Freewheeling — I met him one time and he loved barbecue and it seemed like that as long as he could get something to eat he's all right with playing the horn. Yeah, I met him once and he was a great guy to know.

MR: How about Al Grey?

FW: I didn't know Al Grey real good, but he kind of played like J.J. and me. Kind of had a skill to play a laughable kind of a trombone. You know he would play like [scats] with the wah-wah. I never learned how to do that either. But he played the horn in a humorous kind of a way. You know?

MR: Good word.

FW: Yeah.

MR: What about Sun Ra?

FW: I didn't know too much about Sun Ra. But my drummer played with him and we talk about him often you know. And he was an attention mongrel. He wanted attention so he created this, from the sky, much like George Clinton. You know I think George kind of learned a lot from him.

MR: It's funny you say that because the reason I brought it up, I was looking at some "Parliament Funkadelic" video this morning and it made me think of Sun Ra. Like these guys had the same kind of outrageous, look-at-me type approach.

FW: Yeah. And I think more people look at people than listen to them you know? But if you put them both together, like Bootsie. Bootsie is a person that has the funk in his body but he looked like a star child. Like he had — you see him before you hear him but then you

might hear him before you see him. But if you put the two together you've got a monster entertainer. You know? So that's the way George Clinton is too you know.

MR: Do you get checks in the mail from people who are sampling your music? Or do you get checks in the mail and you go what is this for?

FW: Yeah. I get a lot of those. I don't question it, I just put them in the bank. Thank you very much you know. Because if I tried to — you know one thing I haven't done, I didn't document everything that I have done. If like all that list you've got of me you know, if I had kept a list like that I could probably gather millions of dollars you know. But I didn't document a lot of stuff. You know? And I don't know what I did on what things — I just let a lot of stuff slip away. You know? But it's a gift from God and so I can give it to whoever I want to have it. So if I played on your album or gave you some kind of inspiration or something then you're welcome to it. Because it's free for me and it's free for you too.

MR: That's a great quote from you. Wonderful attitude. What's coming up — you just got back from Europe, is that correct?

FW: Yeah, it was a hard, hard tour. And that's why I'm going to slow down you know? I did two weeks with my band, the New JBs and we did a lot of shows and went directly to another group that I played with, it's called Generations. It features Leonardo Corradi on the organ, he's a young man that plays organ like Jimmy Smith — I mean far, way, way better than Jimmy Smith. And — from Italy. And a drummer from Paris. So we did a trio thing too for two weeks. And that took a lot out of me you know, that's why I'm coughing now. So I think I've got to slow down from now on you know. That showed me that I'm — it's telling me I should act my age. Because I'm not a young man anymore, although I enjoyed doing it, but getting from place to place is getting to be a little difficult now.

MR: Do you have family members that help you out with the logistics and all that?

FW: Oh yeah, my daughter, my daughter Joya, she — and my other two daughters they help me out and my son, he shows me how to use Finale and all of this kind of stuff. And my oldest boy, although he's not doing it anymore, but he helped me on a lot of tunes you know. Yeah, they all help me. But my daughter Joya is the one that takes care of me all the time.

MR: Yeah, and I can attest that she does a fine job helping set this interview up today.

FW: Yeah, yeah, yeah.

MR: Well last sort of question — you seem like a man of faith and over the years has the profession of music challenged your faith sort of like the disconnect between the two? Maybe even going back to when you were a kid?

FW: I don't know. I have faith in what I believe in you know. I don't understand a lot of things and so I don't join any religions or anything like that. Because I don't understand it. And what I do understand is most religions don't make sense to me you know. So all I know is what I call God and what God has done for me you know. And that's — the faith that I have is that I got it from God, I know it's from God or whatever you want to call God. Whatever it is gave me this talent, this ability to do like I do. And maybe some day I'll figure it out but I haven't figured it out yet. And until then I just believe that I should be a good person and not treat anybody bad and not boast about anything that I've done because I know it's not me, it's a natural ability that I have that is from God, what I call God.

MR: Thank you for sharing that. That was actually the second last question. I wonder if you can tell me about that what looks like a gold record behind you.

FW: Oh that's just one of them. The rest — see I'm in Montgomery, Alabama. When my wife died in South Carolina, I lived in South Carolina for thirty years and my wife died and I came to Montgomery to visit my sister, who lives here in Montgomery. And I ran into my first girlfriend who lives here and she invited me to live with her. So reluctantly I moved little stuff, little stuff, little stuff out, and now everything I own is in this place. So that's just one gold record. That was from the S.O.S. band that I did arranging for. Yeah. "Take Your Time, Do It Right" that was the name of the tune.

MR: All right. Well this has been a fascinating chat and I really appreciate the time and the — your memories.

FW: Yeah. Well I appreciate you for asking me all these questions you know. And I see that you've got Joe Williams on your wall there.

MR: That's right. Did you get to play behind him with the Basie band?

FW: Oh yeah.

MR: Yeah.

FW: You know when I was with the Basie band. I joined, I'd been with them for a year. In that year we did every music festival in the world I think. I don't think we missed one, there was Montreux, the North Sea, and in Japan. Joe Williams did most of them. We did the Norman Granz tour. And I was fortunate to be on all of those records — I mean all those festivals with Count Basie. But I had to leave because they weren't paying much money you know. But yeah, I got to know Joe Williams real good. He was a good friend of mine.

MR: He's a good friend of this college. He actually helped get this interview project started back in 1995.

FW: Is that right?

MR: Yes. And the band played here with him in ’96 and your friend Bill Hughes was on the band of course at that time. What a guy.

FW: Yeah, yeah, lot of memories. Lot of memories.

MR: Well you take good care of yourself, all right?

FW: All right, you take care of yourself too, you know?

MR: Okay.

FW: Thank you, Monk.

MR: Okay.

FW: Bye-bye.